

# **Student-Run Computing Facility**

## **Chair's Report to the Annual General Meeting**

*20 March 2026*

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### **What Is the SRCF?**

We are, in effect, a small infrastructure provider run entirely by volunteers that is guardian to over 2 decades (a long time in the digital world!) of the University's history.

### **What Is Wrong?**

I will be direct: the SRCF's governance arrangements are not adequate for the responsibilities we have inadvertently assumed during the COVID pandemic.

#### **Availability**

At the time of writing, only two system administrators are routinely available in person in Cambridge. For a service that provides infrastructure to “Nobel Prize winners in Physics”<sup>1</sup>, this represents a dual point of failure that is also a dual point of trust. If those two individuals were simultaneously unavailable — whether through illness, travel, or some other misfortune— the SRCF would have to rely on the services of a former sysadmin who happens to have access to the SRCF's machines by virtue of his job at the Computer Laboratory.

#### **Credential Management**

During my tenure, I discovered that the credentials to our domain registry were held in plaintext, and that there was no mandatory two-factor authentication in place.<sup>2</sup>

This meant that should one of the committee or sysadmin accounts have been compromised, an adversary could have compromised the availability of all SRCF provisions<sup>3</sup>. There is reason to believe that payment account credentials may also be stored in plaintext. The SRCF does not use a managed password system with delegation, audit logging, or access control. Credentials are shared informally between system administrators on an ad hoc basis.

This is not a theoretical risk. It is a description of the current state of affairs.

#### **Information Asymmetry**

The Committee is, in constitutional terms, responsible for the system administrators and the services they operate. In practice, the Committee cannot exercise that responsibility because it does not have the information to do so.

The SRCF's internal documentation consists of an executive wiki that is, by its own admission, incomplete, poorly formatted, and maintained on a “complain, or better yet fix it” basis. There is no structured handover process, no systematic onboarding documentation, no incident log accessible to the Committee, and no systematic record of what privileged access exists or who holds it. The Committee governs blind.

#### **Inversion of Control**

On 28 July 2020, the Committee passed a series of resolutions that formalised a governance structure in which the system administrator team controls its own composition. Under those resolutions, new system administrators cannot be appointed without a

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<sup>1</sup>This allegation has not been able to be confirmed as of the time of writing.

<sup>2</sup>This has been rectified via an interim account, pending reforms in credential management.

<sup>3</sup>Mythic Beasts, our registry of choice, is based in Cambridge, so in practice the outage time would not be too long, but the underlying vulnerability still holds true.

recommendation from the existing team. The team defined its own categories, its own activity criteria, and its own removal process. The Committee's role was reduced to ratifying decisions already made by the people it is supposed to oversee.<sup>4</sup>

This is the precise inversion of the constitutional relationship between the Committee and the system administrators described in Articles 5 and 6.

### The Broader Context

In 2020, the University decommissioned its homegrown Hermes email service in favour of Microsoft Exchange Online. The University's Information Services cited the burden of running on-premises infrastructure, the difficulty of managing spam and malware, compliance and security concerns, and — critically — the fact that Hermes knowledge and expertise were in short supply.<sup>5</sup> The same article noted that after decommissioning, non-Microsoft email options would remain available only via the Student-Run Computing Facility — but not centrally managed.

The SRCF is now, in effect, the last piece of legacy Cambridge email infrastructure still in operation, running on volunteer effort with no formal governance, no structured handover, and two system administrators routinely available in person. The University concluded that it could not sustain Hermes with professional staff and institutional funding. We are attempting to sustain comparable services with neither.

The risks of allowing legacy infrastructure to be governed informally are well documented in the wider public sector. The UK government's own experience — catalogued in parliamentary reports, the CDDO Legacy IT Risk Assessment Framework, and the technical press<sup>6</sup> — demonstrates that systems maintained on inherited knowledge, informal processes, and goodwill accumulate technical and organisational debt that eventually becomes unmanageable.

The SRCF is smaller than a government department, but the structural problem is identical: we are running services beyond the capacity of our present arrangements to govern them, and we are relying on the continued goodwill and availability of a very small number of individuals to keep things working.

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<sup>4</sup>See <https://www.srcf.net/minutes/2020-07-28>.

<sup>5</sup>*The Register*, "University of Cambridge to decommission its homegrown email service Hermes in favour of Microsoft Exchange Online," 4 August 2020: [https://www.theregister.com/2020/08/04/cambridge\\_uni\\_decommissioning\\_hermes\\_email/](https://www.theregister.com/2020/08/04/cambridge_uni_decommissioning_hermes_email/).

<sup>6</sup>See HM Government, *Managing Legacy Technology* (2023); CDDO, *Legacy IT Risk Assessment Framework* (2023); *The Register*, "Why the UK public sector still creaks along on COBOL," 15 August 2025.

## What the Motions Before This Meeting Do

The motions before this meeting are designed as a single package. They are ordered so that each builds on the last. Taken together, they do the following:

| Motion                             | Effect                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Structural Reforms              | Creates a Register of Members (so we know who we are), a Roll of System Administrators (so we know who has access), a co-option lapse mechanism (so committee membership doesn't drift), and a fee mechanism (so membership can be actively managed).                                                                                                       |
| 2. Quorum                          | Establishes quorum rules for General Meetings and Committee meetings. The GM quorum starts at five and rises automatically as the Register of Members is populated, capping at fifteen. This is deliberately designed as a ratchet: a committee that maintains the Register earns a higher quorum threshold; a committee that neglects it is stuck at five. |
| 3. Committee Meeting Cadence       | Requires the Committee to meet weekly during Full Term. If it doesn't, the Chair must explain why at the next General Meeting.                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| 4. Audit and Oversight Board       | Creates a standing oversight body — independent of the system administrators — with the power to inspect logs, require explanations, and escalate to a General Meeting if the Committee fails to act. The Board cannot hold privileged access itself; it watches, it does not operate.                                                                      |
| 5. Ordinances                      | Gives the Committee the power to make binding rules (Ordinances) below the level of the Constitution. This fills the gap between “full constitutional amendment at a GM” and “whatever someone with root decides.” Ordinances are published, reviewed annually, and can be repealed by a General Meeting.                                                   |
| 6. System Administrator Governance | Repeals the resolutions of 28 July 2020. Establishes the Committee's sole authority over sysadmin appointments. Creates a System Administrator in Committee role to give the sysadmin team a voice on the Committee without control over their own oversight. Permanently prohibits any veto by sysadmins over their own appointments.                      |

## What These Motions Do Not Do

These motions are constitutional machinery. They establish *who decides what* and *how decisions are recorded and reviewed*. They do not, by themselves, fix the operational problems described above.

Four operational changes are, in my judgement, urgently needed but are not matters for the Constitution. They are listed in order of strategic priority.

1. **Pursue formal recognition by the University Information Services as a non-school institution.** The SRCF currently exists in an undefined space in the University's institutional taxonomy. This means that our relationship with UIS is not normalised: we are an edge case in their service management processes, and our access to core University infrastructure — including Lookup directory services<sup>7</sup> — depends on informal arrangements rather than defined entitlements. Formal recognition as a non-school institution would normalise UIS relations, place the SRCF within the University's Service Management Portfolio on a defined compliance footing, and guarantee directory access through supported channels. This is not a technical change; it is a political one, and it requires the Committee to engage directly with UIS. The governance reforms proposed in these motions — in particular the Register of Members, the Roll of System Administrators, and the Ordinance framework — will materially strengthen the SRCF's case for recognition by demonstrating that the Facility operates under a formal, auditable governance structure.
2. **A hosted cloud password manager with delegation and audit logging** (e.g. 1Password Business, Bitwarden Organisation) to replace plaintext credential storage. This can and should be implemented by the Committee immediately, without waiting for these motions to pass.
3. **Sourcehut (or equivalent) as a control plane** for infrastructure configuration, replacing ad hoc wiki pages and informal knowledge transfer with version-controlled, reviewable, auditable infrastructure-as-code.
4. **Migration of the email infrastructure from the current Postfix/Exim-based setup to Stalwart Mail Server<sup>8</sup>** or an equivalent modern platform.

The present email system consists of multiple mail daemons configured independently and maintained through inherited knowledge. Stalwart is a single binary providing full standards-compliant email with a web-based administration interface — replacing an entire class of informal configuration with a system that can be managed, audited, and handed over without requiring years of accumulated institutional knowledge.

Given that *The Register* identified the SRCF as the last non-Microsoft email option at Cambridge after the University decommissioned Hermes, the reputational and operational case for running that service on maintainable infrastructure is self-evident.

These are recommendations, not resolutions. They will require the Committee and the system administrator team to implement them. What these motions *do* provide is the governance framework — the Ordinance power, the oversight board, the explicit chain of authority — within which those operational decisions can be made, documented, and held to account.

## What Happens If These Motions Fail

The SRCF continues to operate as it does today: on inherited systems, voluntary effort, informal knowledge, and personal trust. That has worked so far. Whether it continues to work depends entirely on the continued availability and goodwill of a very small number of people — and on nothing going seriously wrong in the meantime.

Given the rise in LLM-enhanced attacks, I would prefer not to rely on that.

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<sup>7</sup>At present, the SRCF's access to UIS resources depends on legacy arrangements via the Student Union rather than as an independent entity in its own right. Formal recognition would replace this with a supported, auditable integration path.

<sup>8</sup><https://stalw.art/>